previous government. The YSRCP counters that a Rs 464-crore proposal for the modernisation of the Budameru, initiated during the Telugu Desam Party's 2014 - 2019 term in power, remained on paper too. Beyond the political slugfest, the Water Resources Department has failed to take up the expansion of the Budameru Diversion Channel (BDC)—constructed in 2006-07, it is designed to take the excess floodwater from the Budameru to the Polavaram Right Canal that is connected to the Krishna. That leaves the region vulnerable to repeated flooding every monsoon. After the heavy downpour, with the Krishna in spate, the Polavaram canal could not clear the excess water.

Irrigation experts have suggested that alongside the BDC, the government needs to focus on merging the original Budameru rivulet into the Krishna below the Prakasam barrage. Failure to act will only perpetuate the risk to lives and livelihoods, they warn. Moreover, all this doesn't portend well for Naidu's ambitious plans to develop the new capital Amaravati, situated just 19 kms downriver from Vijayawada.

In all, the floods in Andhra Pradesh displaced around 645,000 people and killed 20 in NTR, Guntur, Bapatla, Palnadu, Krishna, Eluru and West Godavari districts. Over half of the displaced were in NTR district alone because of the havoc in Vijayawada. It left a trail of devastation. Agricultural crops in 180,244 hectares and horticulture crops in 15,109 hectares in 20 districts were damaged. "Both the rains and floods are unprecedented and therefore it should be declared a national calamity," said Naidu, hoping for an infusion of central funds for his cash-strapped state. According to estimates, the losses amounted to Rs 6,880 crore. Funding reconstruction and rehabilitation initiatives add to Naidu's challenges. ■

POLL BUGLE SOUNDED

By Amitabh Srivastava

On September 15, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived in Ranchi, a heavy downpour prevented his helicopter from taking off for Jamshedpur–125 km from Jharkhand's capital–where he was scheduled to address a public meeting. Undeterred, he flagged off six Vande Bharat Express trains and laid the foundation stones for crucial railway projects via video conference. Later, he travelled to the steel city by road to address the gathering.

From the stage, Modi reminded the audience that it was the BJP that gave birth to Jharkhand, and called the ruling parties–the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM), Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) and Congress–the state's three greatest enemies. Modi's rally effectively put the state with 81 assembly seats in full election mode, although the Election Commission has yet to announce the poll dates–set for November. The BJP is also revving its electoral engine, with its Parivartan Yatra set to intensify the campaign.





As PM Modi's Jamshedpur rally raised the state's political temperature, the ruling coalition, led by Hemant Soren, is for now banking on a series of populist welfare schemes

To counter the BJP's onslaught, chief minister Hemant Soren and the Congress recognise the urgency of solidifying their alliance, which has the support of 45 MLAs. Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has already claimed that the alliance would win with a "massive majority"–a testament to his party's faith in Hemant's electoral game plan. But the stakes are high, especially since the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance clinched nine of the 14 Lok Sabha seats in the general election.

To start with, a series of populist welfare schemes are central to Hemant's election strategy, with the Maiya Samman Yojana at the forefront. With over 4.5 million women approved for the scheme that provides a monthly stipend of Rs 1,000 to all women aged 18-50 years, Hemant is eager to consolidate the support of a vote bloc that often plays a crucial role in family and community voting decisions. "As many as seven CMs and former CMs have been deployed by the BJP to defeat us. But the 'Didi Lioness' will send them packing," the CM told a gathering of beneficiaries in Ranchi on September 4.

Meanwhile, the BJP–with 25 MLAs in the assembly–is newly laser-focused on tribal voters. In Jharkhand, 28 seats are reserved for Scheduled Tribes, who form 26 per cent of the state's population. The party's poor showing in these seats–it won only two–is largely attributed to its defeat in 2019. The situation hasn't improved: it lost all five ST-reserved Lok Sabha seats this year.

A part of the BJP's comeback strategy is to wean high-profile tribal leaders away from the JMM. The import of former CM Champai Soren from the party last month signalled the BJP's intent to weaken Hemant's tribal support. Champai's switch to the BJP is particularly significant in the Kolhan region, a JMM stronghold where the BJP was roundly defeated in 2019. The BJP's tribal outreach is over and above its broader nationalist rhetoric. It has repeatedly raised the contentious issue of Bangladeshi infiltration, particularly among non-tribal voters. By labelling the Hemant government as ineffective in addressing this issue, the BJP aims to warm that side of the fence too. As the race heats up, the rhetoric is getting supercharged. ■